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Who Can Conquer the Ego? - When Even “I Have Conquered It” Becomes an Object of Awareness

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English Contemplation

The ego can survive even the project of conquering the ego. A gross sense of superiority may be recognized, only to return in subtler forms: "I am humble," "I am detached," "I am realized," or finally, "I have conquered the ego." The decisive inquiry is therefore not how to create a stronger spiritual identity, but whether the very sense of "I" that claims victory is itself being perceived.

If body, thought, emotion, memory and ego are all known, then none of them can by itself be the ultimate knower. Witness-consciousness is an indispensable doorway in practice, but even the thought "I am the witness" should not become a new spiritual possession.

The ripening of this inquiry does not require withdrawal from action. When the burden of doership lightens, action can continue with greater clarity. Knowledge that truly softens ego naturally tends toward compassion, service and humility. The question is no longer "How great is my realization?" but "How freely can life serve without making a monument to the one who serves?"

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